

Spinosaurids

Spinosaurids were huge, sail-backed dinosaurs that lived in swamps and estuaries. With their crocodile-like snouts and powerful clawed hands, they were ideally built for catching the monster fish of the time. They were also skilled at hunting on land.

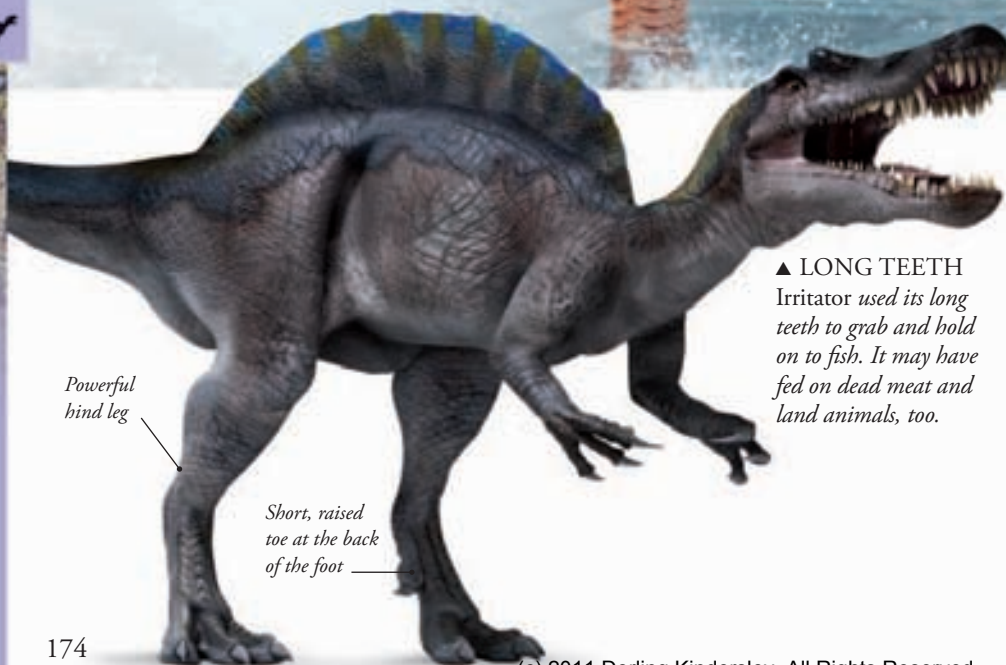
Spinosaurus

SPINE-oh-SORE-us



- **When** 97 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Morocco, Libya, Egypt
- **Habitat** Tropical swamps
- **Length** 60 ft (18 m)
- **Diet** Fish and other animals

Even bigger than *Tyrannosaurus*, *Spinosaurus* was the largest land-dwelling predator of all time. What made it spectacular was an enormous “sail” running along its back. This was supported by spines made of bone, which were as tall as a man—giving it the name *Spinosaurus*, meaning “spine lizard.” It may have hunted on land and in water, just like crocodiles today. It probably ate smaller dinosaurs, turtles, and birds, as well as fish.



Powerful
hind leg

Short, raised
toe at the back
of the foot

▲ LONG TEETH

Irritator used its long teeth to grab and hold on to fish. It may have fed on dead meat and land animals, too.

Irritator

IH-rih-tay-tore



- **When** 110 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Brazil
- **Habitat** Lakesides
- **Length** 26 ft (8 m)
- **Diet** Meat and fish

In 1996 this spinosaurid's long, crocodile-like skull was discovered in Brazil by a fossil hunter. Its name is the result of a clumsy attempt to mend the snout with plaster, which irritated the scientists who tried to undo the damage. In addition to a sail along its back, it may also have had a small crest on the back of its head.